Seeing Through Photographs ✕

Today's goal • 3/3 items

Module 1
Introduction to Seeing Through Photographs

Module 2
One Subject, Many Perspectives

Part I: Introduction
- ✓ Introduction to Module 1 — Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Artistic Equivalents — Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Vik Muniz on Photographing the Familiar — Video • 3 min

Part II: Telescopes and Cameras
- ✓ Introduction to Part II: Surface, Scale, and Technology — Video • 2 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Moons and Surfaces — Reading • 5 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Eugène Atget. Pendant l'éclipse. 1912 — Video • 3 min
- ✓ Hear More: Liz Deschenes on Tilt/Swing (360° field of vision, version 1), 2009 — Video • 1 min
- ✓ Surface, Scale, Technology — Dialogue • 15 min

Part III: Seeing the Unseen
- ✓ Introduction to Part III: Man on the Moon — Video • 2 min
- ✓ Photographs by NASA — Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on U.S.G.S. and NASA, Surveyor III. Surface of the Moon, Day 319, W-F. 1967 — Video • 1 min
- ✓ Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- ✓ Who Does the Moon Belong To? — Reading • 4 min

Part IV: It's Only a Paper Moon
- ✓ Introduction to Part IV: Vernacular and Fine Art Photographs of the Moon — Video • 3 min
- ✓ Moon Phases — Reading • 6 min
- ✓ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Ansel Adams. Moonrise, Hernandez, New Mexico. 1941 — Video • 3 min
- ✓ Man on the Moon and Paper Moons — Dialogue • 15 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- ✓ Optional Readings and Resources — Reading • 10 min
- ✓ Practice Memory Check — Practice Assignment • Grade: 100%
- ✓ Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges — Reading • 10 min

Module 3
Documents and the Documentary

Part I: Introduction
- ✓ Introduction to Module 3 — Reading • 2 min
- ✓ Sarah Meister on Documents and the Documentary — Video • 3 min

Part II: Framing Reality
- ✓ Facts and Fictions — Reading • 6 min
- ○ **Fictions and Facts** — Reading • 6 min
- ○ Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- ○ Hear More: Mike Mandel on Evidence, 1977 — Video • 4 min
- ○ Hear More: Thomas Demand on Room (Zimmer), 1996 — Video • 1 min

Part III: Words and Pictures
- ○ Artist Spotlight: Dorothea Lange — Reading • 4 min
- ○ Practical Scenario — Real-world application • 5 min
- ○ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Dorothea Lange. Migrant Mother. 1936 — Video • 2 min
- ○ Hear More: Sarah Meister on Dorothea Lange. On the Road to Los Angeles, California. March 1937 — Video • 1 min
- ○ Artist Spotlight: Gordon Parks — Reading • 4 min

Part IV: Focus on New Documents, 1967
- ○ Introduction to Part IV: Sarah Meister on New Documents — Video • 3 min
- ○ New Documents: Arbus, Friedlander, and Winogrand — Reading • 4 min

Part V: Review and Respond
- ○ Practice Memory Check — Practice Assignment • 30 min
- ○ Optional Discussion Prompts and Creative Challenges — Reading • 10 min
- ○ Optional Readings and Resources — Reading • 10 min

Module 4
One and Another

Module 5
Constructing Narratives, Challenging Histories

Module 6
Pictures of People

Module 7
Ocean of Images

Fictions and Facts

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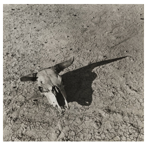
Arthur Rothstein



Arthur Rothstein. *Skull, Badlands, South Dakota*. May 1936. Gelatin silver print, 7 3/8 × 7 1/2" (18.7 × 19 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Gift of the artist

Arthur Rothstein was working as a photographer for the Farm Security Administration when he took a number of photographs featuring this sun-bleached steer skull. These images were picked up by the Associated Press and published in multiple newspapers. However, readers quickly pieced together that Rothstein had placed and photographed the same skull in different positions within the South Dakota Badlands. Many were outraged by his staging, and opponents of President Franklin Delano Roosevelt and his New Deal policies used these images as proof that the government was distorting reality and exaggerating the level of devastation experienced during the Great Depression.

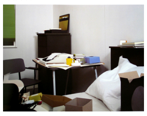
Larry Sultan and Mike Mandel

Larry Sultan and Mike Mandel. *Evidence*. 1977. Artists' book. Publisher: D.A.P./Distributed Art Publishers, Inc. © 1977, 2003 Mike Mandel and Larry Sultan. © 2003 D.A.P./Distributed Art Publishers, Inc. All illustrations © 2003 Mike Mandel and/or Larry Sultan. Photo: Marily Konstantinopoulou

To explore the ways in which context influences our understanding of photographic images, Larry Sultan and Mike Mandel produced *Evidence*, an exhibition and a book of photographs obtained from the archives of U.S. government agencies, universities, and corporations. The two artists sifted through more than two million prints, selecting 59 images for the book (82 for the exhibition) and presenting them without captions or other forms of identifying information. The absence of textual references combined with the idiosyncratic sequencing of the images demonstrates how context (or its lack) affects the way we read and interpret photographs.

Sultan and Mandel explain their project further: "By definition these images are records and by implication they are cultural artifacts. This is not a compilation of photographs that define any specific place in time but rather a poetic exploration upon the restructuring of imagery." This statement reminds us that while photographs appear to be objective pieces of evidence, their meaning is always shaped by subjectivity and a photographer's intention.

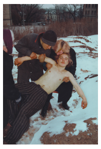
Thomas Demand



Thomas Demand. *Room (Zimmer)*. 1996. Chromogenic color print, 67 3/4 × 7' 7 3/8" (172 × 232 cm). Gift of the Nina W. Werblow Charitable Trust. © 2020 Thomas Demand/Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York/VG Bild-Kunst, Bonn

Thomas Demand used paper to stage the scene in *Room (Zimmer)*. Using a photograph as his source, he built a re-creation of the hotel room where the controversial American writer and Scientology founder L. Ron Hubbard lived and worked between 1972 and 1973. After completing his model, Demand photographed it, creating an image that mimics the original, but that is also full of artifice. The even studio lighting, the sharp creases of the white pillow in the foreground, and the lack of detail on objects in the room, for example, the numberless face of the alarm clock or the keyless typewriter—all of these details signal that the image does not represent reality but a reinterpretation of it. This tension between reality and artifice raises questions about the trust we place in photographs as accurate, unmitigated records of events, times, and places.

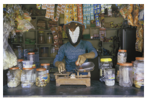
Boris Mikhailov



Boris Mikhailov. *Untitled from the series Case History*. 1997–98. Chromogenic color print, 93 × 49 15/16" (236.2 × 126.8 cm). Acquired through the generosity of Howard Stein. © 2020 Boris Mikhailov/Artists Rights Society (ARS), New York/VG Bild-Kunst, Germany

With his series Case History, Boris Mikhailov confronts viewers with the effects of the Soviet Union's collapse on the homeless and marginalized people of Ukraine. To create these large-scale, raw, color-saturated photographs, Mikhailov paid his subjects and worked with them to enact poses inspired by religious and historical paintings. "This is the first time I paid my models," he explains. "I don't think this is an issue. If models get paid to appear in an advertisement, nobody cares. Why can't I? This gave me the possibility to photograph them, and gave them the possibility to live."

Gauri Gill



Gauri Gill. *Untitled* from the series Acts of Appearance. 2015–ongoing. Pigmented inkjet print, 28 × 41 15/16" (71.1 × 106.5 cm). The Museum of Modern Art, New York. Acquired through the generosity of Robert B. Menschel. © 2020 Gauri Gill

Gauri Gill created the series Acts of Appearance in close collaboration with members of an Adivasi (indigenous) community in Jawhar district, Maharashtra, India. The region is renowned for its papier-mâché objects, including traditional sacred masks depicting deities. These masks are worn during the Bohoda festival, a ritual celebration observed by members of the Kokna tribe. After reflecting upon the possible distance between such traditions and the everyday realities of the present-day Jawhar community, Gill approached local artists and asked them to collaborate with villagers to create a new set of masks that resonated with their own lives. They made masks of familiar people, animals, or objects. Gill and her collaborators then composed scenes of them and others wearing the masks while engaging in routine activities, often improvising as they went. With this approach, the artist hoped to prompt the mask-makers to think about "what happens when we choose to self-reflexively 'play ourselves' or enact the things we do unthinkingly most of the time."

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